undermine them. They tend to be sober, law-abiding types with a punctilious regard for procedures. The dire state of their morale now is a result of Snowden's disclosures. The consequences remain to be seen. The dangers of abuse in a woe-struck agency may be greater than in one where morale and corporate culture are healthy.

One can argue (and I would agree) that the NSA needs reform, that it has become too big, too dependent on private contractors, too sloppy in its security procedures, too hard to oversee and too slippery in its definitions of what it may and may not do. All these shortcomings are cause for concern (though not for panic) and are worthy subjects for discussion. As General Clapper himself has admitted: 'As loath as I am to give any credit for what's happened, which is egregious, I think it's clear that some of the conversations that this has generated, some of the debate, actually probably needed to happen.'[63]

It is hard to dispute that the public should be aware that the NSA has stretched the definition of material 'relevant' to terrorism to include warehousing the phone records of every call made or e-mail sent in America, and that the agency has had serious rows with the FISA court. Thanks to Snowden, the public now knows this. The modest reforms announced by President Obama on January 17th are also a direct result of the Snowden leaks. But such benefits need to be weighed against the costs. Nothing evinced so far justifies the catastrophic damage that the Snowden leaks have done to national security—the worst disaster in the history of American and British intelligence.